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RESOURCE CENTER (/RESOURCE-CENTER) > BLOG (/RESOURCE-CENTER/BLOGS) > NUTRITION > 10 FOODS HIGH IN HEALTHY FATS (AND WHY YOUR BODY NEEDS THEM)

Nutrition

Program Design

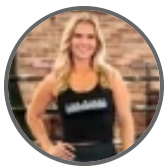
Recovery

10 Foods High in Healthy Fats (and Why Your Body Needs Them)

For years, dietary fat was viewed as something to avoid. Today, we know that's not the full story. In fact, healthy fats play an essential role in supporting overall health and should be part of a balanced eating pattern.

As a [personal trainer \(https://www.nasm.org/products/become-a-personal-trainer\)](https://www.nasm.org/products/become-a-personal-trainer), understanding the role of dietary fat empowers more informed conversations with clients who may still believe that all fats are unhealthy. While [nutrition \(https://www.nasm.org/resource-center/blog/nutrition-for-muscle-recovery\)](https://www.nasm.org/resource-center/blog/nutrition-for-muscle-recovery) recommendations should remain within your scope of practice, a basic understanding of healthy fats supports clients as they work toward their health, wellness, and body-composition goals.

Not all fats are created equally. Unsaturated fats, in particular, offer a variety of health benefits and can be found in many nutrient-dense foods.



[Jacqueline Kaminski \(https://www.nasm.org/resource-center/blog/authors/jacqueline-kaminski\)](https://www.nasm.org/resource-center/blog/authors/jacqueline-kaminski)

MS, RD

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Healthy fats do much more than add flavor and satisfaction to meals. Unsaturated fats have been associated with improved lipid profiles, reduced inflammation, and better cardiovascular health. They also support cell growth, hormone production, organ protection, and the absorption of fat-soluble vitamins such as vitamins A, D, E, and K.

When incorporated as part of a balanced eating plan, healthy fats contribute to both short-term wellness and long-term health outcomes.



UNDERSTANDING THE TWO TYPES OF UNSATURATED FAT

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Unsaturated fats generally fall into two categories: monounsaturated fats and polyunsaturated fats. Both types contribute to a healthy dietary pattern and offer unique nutritional benefits.

Saturated fats can also be included as part of a balanced diet, but current dietary guidelines generally recommend replacing some saturated fats with unsaturated fats when possible:

- Monounsaturated fats are commonly found in foods such as avocados, olives, olive oil, nuts, and seeds. These fats are often associated with heart-health benefits and are a staple of many balanced eating patterns.
- Polyunsaturated fats are found in foods such as fatty fish, walnuts, flax seeds, sunflower seeds, and certain plant oils. These fats include essential fatty acids that the body cannot produce on its own.

THE IMPORTANCE OF OMEGA-3 AND OMEGA-6 FATTY ACIDS

Omega-3 and omega-6 fatty acids are polyunsaturated fats that play important roles throughout the body:

- Omega-3 fatty acids are involved in regulating inflammation, supporting healthy circulation, and producing hormone-like compounds that maintain normal physiological function. Because the body cannot manufacture omega-3s, they must be obtained through food sources.
- Omega-6 fatty acids are also essential and contribute to normal growth and development. Like omega-3s, they must come from dietary sources.



HOW MUCH FAT SHOULD CLIENTS EAT?



Healthy fats are a calorie-dense macronutrient, providing approximately nine calories per gram. While healthy fats are beneficial, portion awareness remains important because calories can add up quickly.

General dietary guidelines suggest that fat can account for approximately 20% to 35% of total calorie intake. However, individual needs vary based on factors such as activity level, health status, preferences, and overall dietary intake.

Personal trainers should encourage clients to seek individualized recommendations from a registered dietitian when specific nutrition guidance is needed. At the same time, earning a credential such as NASM Certified Nutrition Coach (CNC)

(<https://www.nasm.org/products/certified-nutrition-coach>) strengthens your understanding of evidence-based nutrition principles, behavior change strategies (<https://www.nasm.org/resource-center/blog/building-client-habits-that-outlast-training-programs-with-behavior-coaching>), and healthy habit

(<https://www.nasm.org/resource-center/blog/building-habits-that-last>) formation to better support clients within the personal trainer (<https://www.nasm.org/resource-center/blog/why-nasm-certified-nutrition-coach-changes-everything>) scope of practice.

10 FOODS RICH IN HEALTHY FATS

Many whole-food sources of healthy fats also provide valuable vitamins, minerals, fiber, and protein. These foods encourage clients to increase their intake of healthy fats while improving overall diet quality:

- Avocado: Provides monounsaturated fats along with fiber, potassium, and several essential vitamins.
- Chia seeds: Deliver omega-3 fatty acids, fiber, and important minerals.
- Flax seeds: Supply omega-3 fats and fiber while supporting overall dietary quality.
- Full-fat Greek yogurt: Offers healthy fats, protein, and calcium in a convenient package.
- Grass-fed 2% milk: Contains healthy fats along with protein, calcium, and other essential nutrients.
- Hemp seeds: Provide omega-3 and omega-6 fats and contain complete protein.
- Macadamia nuts: Rich in monounsaturated fats and a popular option for healthy snacking.



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- Mackerel: One of the most concentrated dietary sources of omega-3 fatty acids.
 - Salmon: Delivers omega-3 fats, protein, and vitamin D.
 - Walnuts: Contain polyunsaturated fats, including omega-3 fatty acids, and offer a delicious addition to meals and snacks.
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HELPING CLIENTS BUILD A BALANCED NASM APPROACH TO FAT INTAKE (tel:8004606276)

Support clients by explaining informed food choices and building balanced eating habits. Prioritizing minimally processed foods that contain unsaturated fats support their overall health while still enjoying satisfying meals. Foods such as avocados, nuts, seeds, olive oil, and fatty fish all contribute to a nutrient-dense dietary pattern.

Expand your nutrition knowledge and learn evidence-based strategies for supporting healthy behavior change with NASM Certified Nutrition Coach (CNC) (<https://www.nasm.org/products/certified-nutrition-coach>) program.





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FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS ABOUT HEALTHY FATS AND NUTRITION

Are fats bad for your health?

What are the healthiest foods high in fat?



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What is the difference between monounsaturated and polyunsaturated fats?



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Why are omega-3 and omega-6 considered essential fats?

How much fat should clients consume each day?

How can personal trainers talk about healthy fats while staying within their scope of practice?

Have more questions? Explore the [NASM Blog \(https://www.nasm.org/resource-center/blogs\)](https://www.nasm.org/resource-center/blogs) for more evidence-based fitness guidance or contact us at 800-460-6276.

Meet the author

JACQUELINE KAMINSKI

Jacqueline Kaminski, MS, RD, is a registered dietitian and the founder of The Fight Nutritionist, where she provides evidence-based, individualized nutrition plans for athletes and everyday clients alike.

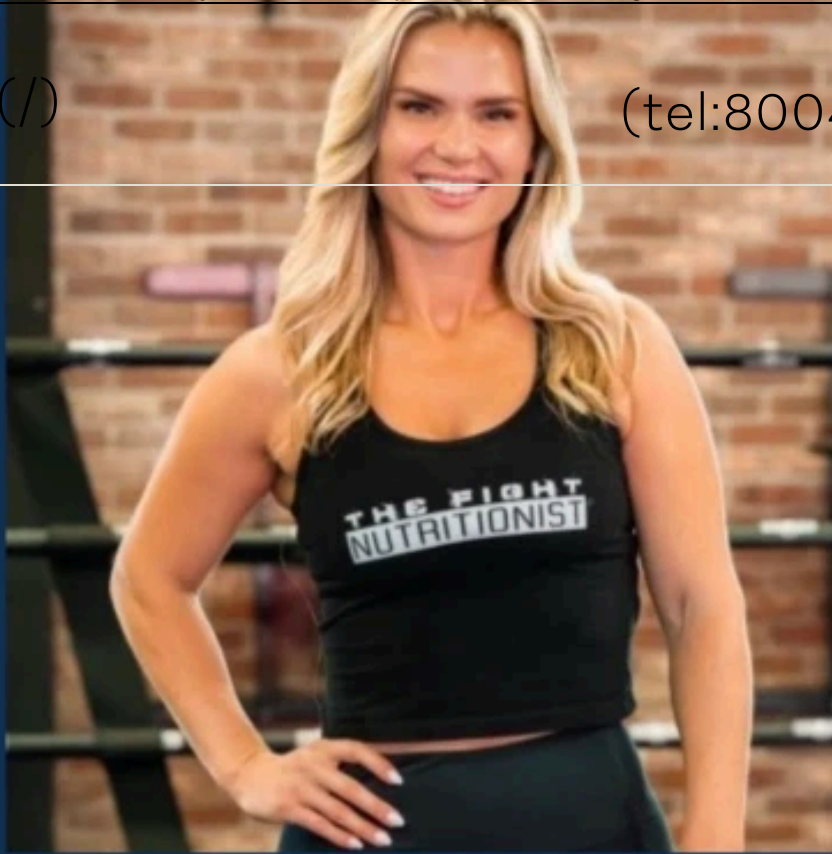
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READY TO TAKE THAT FIRST STEP? LET'S CHAT

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